

35 Few or little?

The words used to describe quantities vary according to a number of factors, including whether you are talking about something countable or uncountable.

⚙️ **New language** "Few," "little," "fewer," "less"

Aa **Vocabulary** Nature and environment

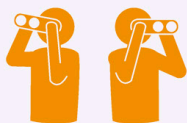
🧑 **New skill** Describing quantities

35.1 KEY LANGUAGE "FEW" FOR SMALL NUMBERS

Use "few" with a plural countable noun to say that there are not many of something. It emphasizes how small the number is. You use "a few" to mean "some." It emphasizes that the number, though small, is enough.

few = not many

There are **few** rare birds here.
We probably won't see any.



a few = some

There are **a few** rare birds here.
We might see one.



35.2 KEY LANGUAGE "LITTLE" FOR SMALL AMOUNTS

Use "little" with an uncountable noun to say that there is not much of something. It emphasizes how small the amount is. You use "a little" to mean "some." It emphasizes that the amount, though small, is enough.



little = not much

I have **little** money left. I can't afford to visit the wildlife park.



a little = some

I have **a little** money left. Should we visit the wildlife park?



TIP

You can add "very" to "few" and "little" to mean "almost none."

35.3 OTHER WAYS TO USE "LITTLE" AND "FEW" FOR SMALL QUANTITIES

Informally, you can use "a (little) bit of" instead of "a little."

There's **a little bit of** the park that we haven't seen yet.

"Little" and "few" can also be used as pronouns to mean "not much / many."

Little can be done when **few** are willing to contribute.

